VIDEO GAME DESIGN

OVERVIEW

Applying leadership and 21st century skills, participants develop a video game that focuses on the annual theme. The game must be interesting, exciting, visually appealing, and intellectually challenging. The game must have high artistic, educational, and social value. The rating of the game must meet the ESRB rating of E for Everyone.

The game and all required documentation must be submitted online pre-conference. Semifinalist teams will participate in an on-site presentation and interview to showcase their video game and to demonstrate the knowledge and expertise they gained during the development of the game.

The theme of the current year's game will be posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

ELIGIBILITY

Five (5) teams per state may participate.

TIME LIMITS

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Participants review the TSA Honor Statement for Competitive Events found in the General Rules.
B. Participants review the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) found in the General Rules.
C. All components of the chapter's entry (video game URL, video game demonstration video URL, and documentation PDF) must be finished, submitted, and accessible via the Internet by 11:59pm ET on a designated date mid-May.
D. Game submitted for evaluation must be greater than three (3) minutes in length of play and must be interactive.
E. A deduction of five (5) points total will be incurred for a game that completes under the three (3) minute time minimum.
F. Timing of the game segment starts with the first image or sound presented.
G. Games must be playable from the deadline until the end of the National TSA Conference.
H. Video game demonstration video must be less than five (minutes). A deduction of five (5) points total will be incurred for a video that goes over the five (5) minute time maximum. The timing of the video starts with the first image or sound presented. The timing of the video ends with the last image or sound.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. A total of fifteen (15) minutes will be allocated for each team's on-site presentation and interview. Each team will be given five (5) minutes to give a presentation on their video game. The remaining ten (10) minutes will be used for an interview session with the judges.

ATTIRE

TSA competition attire is required for this event.

PROCEDURE

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Teams design an online video game.
B. Teams design the game based on the annual theme posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.
C. Video game URL, video game demonstration video URL, and documentation portfolio PDF must be submitted by 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May.
D. Submission information and deadline will be provided in January on the TSA website under *Competition Updates*.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. A list of the twelve (12) semifinalists (in random order) will be posted on the first full day of the conference.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Two (2) representatives from each semifinalist team report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign up for a presentation and interview time.

B. No more than two (2) semifinalist team members report to the assigned time and place to present their video game and to respond to questions about their documentation, game, the game's purpose, value, design, and rules.

C. Participants will present their presentation using their own device. The device must be battery powered (e.g., laptop, tablet). No electricity or Internet connection is provided.

D. The top ten (10) finalists are announced during the awards ceremony.

REGULATIONS AND REQUIREMENTS

Students will work to develop their leadership and 21st century skills in the process of preparing for and participating in this TSA competitive event. The development and application of those skills must be evident in their submission, demonstration, and/or communication pertaining to the entry.

PRE-CONFERENCE/PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. All online game submissions must be a hyperlink to the online game and be accessible for evaluation by the deadline posted on the TSA website under *Competition Updates*. Participants may choose the hosting site, but the hyperlink must point directly to the entry. Entries that request access be granted will not be judged.

B. Entries received, or changes made to submitted entries after this deadline will not be judged.

C. The URL must point to the team's entry. Entries or demonstration videos that require a software download, running an executable file (.exe), or a request that access be granted will not be judged.

D. Video Game:

1. Must be a hyperlink to the online game.
2. Must be the original work of the team.
3. Games must be playable from all computers and browsers.
4. When creating the game, the game must be free of any weapons or violence as stated in the general rules. Please refer to the General Rules and Regulations, H. Prohibited Materials, References, and Images.
5. Work that is not created by the team must have proper documentation, showing copyright permissions and/or license for usage in the game segment.
6. Game instructions must be clear and understandable.
7. Judges must be able to play the game to the third (3rd) level.
8. Game submitted for evaluation must be greater than three (3) minutes in length of play and must be interactive.
9. A deduction of five (5) points total will be incurred for a game that completes under the three (3)-minute time minimum.
10. Timing of the game segment starts with the first image or sound presented.
11. Games must be playable from the submission deadline until the end of the National TSA Conference.
12. Bonus points may be awarded for exceptional game features or content.

E. Video Game Demonstration Video

1. Demonstration video must include the following components:
   a. A tutorial for how to play the game.
   b. Video game being played for at least one (1) level.
   c. Show the code, scripts, files, and game engine used to create the game.
2. Video must not exceed five (5) minutes.
3. A deduction of five (5) points total will be incurred for a game demonstration video that is over the five (5) minute time maximum.
4. Video must not include any identifying information other than the team's identification number.
5. Video needs to be submitted using a URL.

F. Documentation Portfolio:
   1. Portfolio must include the following pages in a multi-page PDF document in this order:
      a. Title page with the event title, the title of the video, the conference city and state, and the year, and the team's identification number; one (1) page
      b. Purpose and description of the game, the target audience, and a detailed explanation of how to play the game, including a list of control functions; maximum of two (2) pages
      c. A hand-drawn storyboard, which depicts the design concept of the video game; pages as needed
      d. Student Copyright Checklist (2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); one (1) page
      e. Permission letters for the use of copyrighted material; pages as needed (if applicable).
      f. Resources and AI Reflection (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); maximum of four (4) pages

G. Bonus points may be awarded for exceptional game features or content.

H. Teams will submit the URL to the video game, the URL to the video game demonstration video, and the PDF of the documentation portfolio.

EVALUATION

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. First three (3) levels of the game

B. Video game demonstration video

C. Documentation portfolio

D. Up to ten (10) bonus points may be added by the judges for exceptional game features, or for content showing exemplary educational and social value.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Presentation

B. Interview

Refer to the official rating form for more information.

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is permitted for this event. Refer to the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) for Competitive Events found in the General Rules and Regulations.

STEM INTEGRATION

This event aligns with the STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) educational standards.

LEADERSHIP AND 21ST CENTURY SKILLS

This event provides opportunity for students to build and develop leadership and 21st century skills including but not limited to – Communication, Collaboration/Social Skills, Initiative, Problem Solving/Risk Taking, Critical Thinking, Perseverance/Grit, Creativity, Relationship Building/Teamwork, Dependability/Integrity, and Flexibility/Adaptability

CAREERS RELATED TO THIS EVENT

This competition has connections to one (1) or more of the careers below:

- Animator
- Computer programmer
- Electronic game designer
- Electronic game technician
- Writer

Participant/Team ID# _____

VIDEO GAME DESIGN

2027 & 2028 OFFICIAL RATING FORM

HIGH SCHOOL

Judges: Using minimal (1-4 points), adequate (5-8 points), or exemplary (9-10 points) performance levels as a guideline in the rating form, record the scores earned for the event criteria in the column spaces to the right. The X1 or X2 notation in the criteria column is a multiplier factor for determining the points earned. (Example: an "adequate" score of 7 for an X1 criterion = 7 points; an "adequate" score of 7 for an X2 criterion = 14 points.) A score of zero (0) is acceptable if the minimal performance for any criterion is not met.

Go/No Go Specifications

- Before judging the entry, ensure that the items below are present; indicate presence with a check mark in the box.
- If an item is missing, leave the box next to the item blank and place a check mark in the box labeled ENTRY NOT EVALUATED.
- If a check mark is placed in the ENTRY NOT EVALUATED box, the entry is not to be judged.

☐ Game is playable
☐ PDF of the documentation portfolio is submitted
☐ ENTRY NOT EVALUATED

PRELIMINARY GAME DESIGN (70 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Creativity and Artisanship (X2)	Game lacks creativity; poor artisanship and development are evident.	Game exhibits adequate creativity and artisanship.	Game is highly creative and well-crafted.	
Technical Skill (X2)	Game lacks originality and shows few technical skills.	Game is original and shows some evidence of programming skills.	Game is original, highly artistic, and shows evidence of programming skills.	
Storyline/Flow of the Game (X1)	Game follows little or no story line; there is limited logical flow to the game.	Game follows a story line and flows adequately from one (1) scene/level to another.	Game is well-organized and flows smoothly from one (1) scene/level to the next.	
Overall Appeal (X2)	Playing the game is not enjoyable; interacting in game play is a struggle, due to the game's illogical sequencing.	Game is somewhat interesting, easy, and enjoyable to play; most design concepts are incorporated.	Game is innovative and entertaining; design principles are incorporated, which make playing the game easy and enjoyable.	
			PRELIMINARY GAME DESIGN SUBTOTAL (70 points)	

TIME DEDUCTIONS	
Five (5) points will be incurred for a game that completes under the three (3) minute time limit. Enter a five (5) if the game completes under the three (3) minute time limit.	

PRELIMINARY VIDEO DEMONSTRATION & DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO (50 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Video Game Demonstration (X1)	Not all video demonstration components are included and/or video is unorganized.	Most of video demonstration components are included and organized.	Outstanding skills are evident in the presentation of the organization and demonstration of the video demonstration, which includes all required components.	
Portfolio Components (X1)	Portfolio is unorganized and/or is missing three (3) or more components.	Portfolio has most components and is generally organized per the order of the event guide listing; it has sufficient content.	All components are included in the portfolio; content and organization per the order of the event guide listing are excellent.	
Game Directions and Control Function (X1)	Game explanation is difficult to follow; functions provided are illogical or incorrect.	Game directions can be followed, but at times they do not sync with overall workings of the game; most control functions are adequate.	Game explanation is easy to follow, and control functions are well-matched for the game.	
Storyboard (X1)	Storyboard is sloppy, disorganized, and incomplete and/or does not follow overall flow of the game design.	Storyboard is generally organized and includes aspects and overall scenes of the game.	Storyboard is complete, concise, neat, and follows the overall flow of the game.	
Resources and AI Reflection (X1)	Form is incomplete or vague and does not clearly explain whether or how AI was used, showing little connection to the submission or understanding of effectiveness and ethics.	Form is complete and clearly explains AI use or the lack thereof with connections to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable), addressing effectiveness and ethical considerations with adequate analysis.	Form is complete, concise, and specific, critically evaluating how AI or non-AI tools shaped decisions and outcomes, with strong alignment to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable) and ethical reasoning.	
PRELIMINARY VIDEO DEMONSTRATION & DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO SUBTOTAL (50 points)				

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

TIME DEDUCTIONS	
Five (5) points total will be incurred for a game demonstration video that goes over the five (5) minute time maximum. Enter a five (5) if the game demonstration video is over five (5) minutes.	

PRELIMINARY SUBTOTAL (120 points)	

SEMIFINAL PRESENTATION AND INTERVIEW (60 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Presentation (X2)	Presentation may be missing key elements to provide a proper overview of the game, design process, technology choices, etc.; presenters may appear nervous, poor posture, poor eye contact or lack confidence; presentation may not follow a logical structure, or the presenters may not appear familiar with the content.	Presentation provides a basic overview of the game and the process of developing the game; presentation is organized and structured, the presenters are generally knowledgeable and confident when presenting their content.	Presentation is engaging and provides an overview of the game and discuss topics such as inspiration, design process, technology choices, etc.; presenters are confident, knowledgeable and comfortable with their presentation material, and it's presented in a clear and logical structure.	
Organization (X1)	Participants seem unorganized and unprepared for the interview; an illogical explanation of the game is presented.	Participants are generally prepared for the interview; explanation of the game is communicated and generally organized.	Interview is logical, well-organized, and easy to follow; game explanation is communicated in an organized and concise manner.	
Team Participation (X1)	Majority of the delivery is made by one (1) member of the team; partner(s) may be disengaged in the interview.	Team members generally are engaged in the interview, though one (1) member may take on more responsibility that the other(s).	All team members are actively involved in the interview and responses to the questions; there is shared responsibility among team members.	
Knowledge (X1)	Participants seem to have little understanding of the concepts in their project; answers to questions may be vague.	Participants exhibit an understanding of the concepts in the project.	Participants show clear evidence of a thorough understanding of their project.	
Articulation (X1)	Communication of the design process is unclear, unorganized, and or illogical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are not evident.	Communication of the design process is somewhat logical and clear; leadership and/or 21st century skills are somewhat evident.	Communication of the design process is clear, concise, and logical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are clearly evident.	
			SEMIFINAL PRESENTATION AND INTERVIEW SUBTOTAL (60 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

BONUS (10 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Bonus Points Unique and exceptional features (X1)	Game demonstrates some unique and exceptional features and/or exemplary educational value.	Game is very good but limited in uniqueness.	Game is outstanding and unique.	

To arrive at the TOTAL score, add any subtotals and subtract rules violation points, as necessary. TOTAL (180 points)

Comments:

I certify these results to be true and accurate to the best of my knowledge.

JUDGE

Printed name: _____ Signature: _____

VIDEO GAME DESIGN
EVENT COORDINATOR INSTRUCTIONS

PERSONNEL

A. Event coordinator

B. Judges:

   1. Preliminary round, two (2) or more
   2. Semifinal Round, two (2) or more (preferably the same judges from the preliminary round)

MATERIALS

A. Coordinator's packet, containing:

   1. Event guidelines, one (1) copy for the coordinator and for each judge
   2. TSA Event Coordinator Report

B. Stopwatch

C. Interview questions

D. Tables for entries

E. One (1) extension cord for the semifinalist evaluation team

F. One (1) power bar with surge protection for semifinalists, as needed

G. Laptop computer with high speed Internet capability

H. Tables and chairs for event coordinator, semifinalist judges, and participants

RESPONSIBILITIES

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. National TSA will collect entries until 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May. The results are shared with the CRC manager, event coordinator, and assigned judges.

B. Review entries as they are submitted to the designated online storage utility.

C. Manage communication and Pre-conference evaluation (at least two [2] or more judges should be recruited earlier in the year). Coordinate with National TSA and/or the Judge Manager.

D. Confirm with judges that video games are not playable by using different devices and/or browsers.

AT THE CONFERENCE

A. Attend the mandatory coordinator's meeting at the designated time and location.

B. Report to the CRC room and check the contents of the coordinator's packet.

C. Review the event guidelines and check to see that enough personnel have been scheduled.

D. Inspect the area or room in which the event is to be held for appropriate set-up, including room size, chairs, tables, outlets, etc. Notify the event manager of any potential problems.

E. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. On the first full day of competition, post a list of the twelve (12) semifinalists in random order.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. At least one (1) hour before the event is scheduled to begin, meet with judges, and review time limits, procedures, regulations, evaluation, and all other details related to the event.

B. Determine the procedure for breaking ties before the on-site competition begins.

C. No more than two (2) semifinalist representatives report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign up and participate in the on-site presentation and interview.

D. Distribute the guidelines for the interview.

E. Manage completion of the on-site interviews.

F. Decisions about rules violations must be discussed and verified with the judges, event coordinator, and CRC manager to determine either:

   1. To deduct twenty percent (20%) of the total possible points in this round or
   2. To disqualify the entry

   The event coordinator, judges, and CRC manager must initial either of these actions on the rating form.

G. If necessary, manage security and the removal of materials from the event area.